a practitioner's diagnostic

Open Weights and the Colony Question

What Europe's AI Sovereignty Actually Requires

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On 24 July 2026, more than two hundred and thirty American companies signed an open letter to the White House arguing that open-weight AI models are the foundation of American AI leadership. The letter is strong. Read from Europe, it is a diagnosis of what Europe does not yet have. The question is not whether open weights matter. The question is whether a continent of 450 million citizens, 24 official languages, and the most advanced privacy framework on earth will use them to build sovereignty or will rent its intelligence from providers who signed that letter.

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On 24 July 2026, more than two hundred and thirty companies, including every name that matters in American technology, signed an open letter arguing that open-weight AI models are the foundation of American AI leadership. The original letter carried twenty-five signatories hosted by NVIDIA. Within twenty-four hours Google and OpenAI, neither of them historically associated with the open-weight position, had added their names. That political detail matters. When companies that built their dominance on closed models sign a letter defending open weights, the strategic calculation behind the signature is as significant as the letter itself.

The letter is well-argued, well-timed, and precisely targeted at the policy window the current administration has opened. It is also, read from Europe, a document of extraordinary strategic clarity about a position Europe has not yet begun to hold.

The American letter makes seven claims. Open weights expand access. They strengthen competition. They give customers control. They improve safety through transparency. They are the only path to broad defensive cybersecurity capability. They do not carry the risks that closed-model concentration carries. And distillation is a legitimate technique, not misappropriation.

Every one of these claims applies with equal or greater force to Europe. And yet no European letter exists. No equivalent coalition of European signatories has formed. No institutional voice from the continent has articulated, with this degree of precision, what open weights mean for a jurisdiction that is not defending a lead but attempting to avoid permanent dependency.

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I.

The Sovereignty Question, Stated Plainly

The United States has the compute, the capital, the talent concentration, and the institutional momentum to lead in frontier AI whether the models are open or closed. The American interest in open weights is an interest in diffusion, in making the gains of AI reach every factory and hospital and classroom and farm. It is a generous argument because the United States can afford to be generous ; it leads in both open and closed.

Europe cannot afford to be generous with itself. Europe's interest in open weights is not diffusion but survival. If European institutions, European public services, European industrial champions, and European defence establishments cannot run advanced AI on their own infrastructure, under their own legal frameworks, with their own capacity to audit and modify and improve, then Europe becomes a tenant of American technology in the most consequential infrastructure layer of the century. The word for a jurisdiction that rents its critical infrastructure from a foreign provider and cannot inspect what it rents is not "partner." The word is "dependency," and the trajectory it describes is familiar to anyone who has studied the history of infrastructure control across asymmetric power relations.

I write this from a specific vantage. I am Franco-Sénégalais. I have spent twelve years operating European programmes across six jurisdictions and coordinating a fifteen-partner DFID consortium in West Africa. I know what institutional dependency looks like from the inside, because I have worked in the governance architectures that colonial and post-colonial infrastructure arrangements produce. The AI sovereignty question is not abstract to me. It is the same question I have watched play out in telecommunications, in agricultural supply chains, in financial infrastructure, and in the aid architecture itself. The pattern is legible ; a jurisdiction that does not build its own capacity in a critical infrastructure layer will rent that capacity from someone who did, and the terms of the rental will not be set by the tenant.

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II.
What Europe Does Not Yet Have

The American letter was signed by more than two hundred and thirty companies. The European equivalent would need signatories from Mistral, OVHcloud, Scaleway, SAP, Deutsche Telekom, Orange, Thales, INRIA, CNRS, Fraunhofer, the European Investment Bank, and every industrial champion from Airbus to Stellantis to Siemens. That coalition does not exist. The institutional reflex in Europe is to regulate AI, not to build the shared infrastructure on which regulation becomes meaningful. The AI Act is an achievement of legal architecture, and its high-risk compliance obligations take full effect on 2 August 2026. But it is not, by itself, a compute strategy, a training-data strategy, or a deployment strategy. You cannot regulate what you do not possess, or rather, you can, but what you regulate is the terms on which someone else's technology enters your jurisdiction, which is regulation as border control rather than regulation as industrial policy. It is worth asking who benefits from that configuration ; it serves incumbent European industries that want to constrain American entrants far more than it serves European startups that want to build.
Europe needs three things it does not have.

First, shared compute at scale. The EuroHPC Joint Undertaking has committed approximately €2.6 billion. American private AI investment reached $109 billion in 2025. The ratio is not a gap ; it is an asymmetry of a different order. European researchers attempting to train frontier or near-frontier models on what is available are not behind ; they are operating in a different category of resource. And the gap is widening, not closing.

Second, shared multilingual training assets. Europe has 24 official languages and approximately 450 million citizens. This is not a detail ; it is the structural test of whether AI infrastructure serves citizens or serves markets. Closed models systematically underserve small-language markets because the commercial incentive to train on Estonian or Maltese or Slovenian is negligible. An Estonian civil servant, a Maltese nurse, a Slovenian teacher deserve AI tools that work in their language with the same reliability as tools that work in English. Open-weight models, fine-tuned on high-quality multilingual corpora assembled as public goods, are the only path to AI that works in every European language rather than in English plus the three or four languages large enough to attract commercial attention. If Europe does not build those corpora, nobody else will.

Third, an industrial application layer. Europe’s strength is not frontier model training. That race, measured in compute expenditure, is between the United States and China, and Europe is not in it. Europe’s strength is institutional depth in manufacturing, healthcare, agriculture, public administration, and defence. Open-weight models fine-tuned for European industrial use cases, running on European infrastructure, under European legal frameworks, are the path to AI sovereignty that Europe can actually walk. The frontier is someone else’s race. The application layer is Europe’s.

There is a further structural argument that the American letter makes for cybersecurity and that applies with equal force to institutional resilience. Concentration in a small number of closed providers creates systemic risk ; a single point of failure at the provider level cascades across every institution that depends on it. Open weights distribute that risk across many deployments, many teams, many auditors. For a continent that learned the cost of single-supplier energy dependency in 2022, the analogy should not need spelling out.

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III.
GDPR as Structural Advantage

The European privacy framework is routinely described, in American technology commentary, as a barrier to AI adoption. This is a misreading. GDPR is the strongest structural argument for open-weight deployment in any jurisdiction on earth.

Open-weight models deployed on-premise or on European cloud infrastructure satisfy the core GDPR requirements by design ; no personal data leaves European soil, no third-party processor risk arises, the full audit trail is available to the data controller, and the right to deletion can be exercised without negotiating with a foreign API provider. Closed-model API calls, by contrast, send European citizens’ data to infrastructure the data controller does not own, cannot audit, and cannot compel to delete. The privacy framework that American commentary treats as an obstacle is, correctly read, the regulatory architecture that makes open weights not merely preferable but, for many use cases, legally required.

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IV.
What Building Looks Like

I do not only write about this. I build the infrastructure I describe.
My GitHub hosts thirty-one open-source tools, from LLM cost monitoring proxies that track API spending in real time, to semantic caching layers that reduce redundant LLM calls, to multi-model routers that classify query complexity and route to the cheapest capable model, to prompt versioning systems with A/B testing and deployment pipelines. These are the instruments that make open-weight deployment operationally viable for organisations that do not have frontier-lab budgets. They are built in the open, documented for practitioners, and available to anyone.

Sovereignty is not a position paper. It is code that runs on your own machines, under your own authority, serving your own citizens in their own languages.

The American letter is a generous invitation to a game America has already won. Europe’s task is not to accept the invitation but to build its own game, on its own terms, with the instruments the open-weight ecosystem makes available.

The instruments exist. The question is whether Europe will use them.

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